

How I Became a Ghost Ch. 1

By Tim Tingle





Chapter 1

Talking Ghost

Choctaw Nation, Mississippi, 1830

MAYBE YOU HAVE never read a book written by a ghost before. I am a ghost. I am not a ghost when this book begins, so you have to pay very close attention. I should tell you something else. I see things before they happen. You are probably thinking, "I wish I could see things before they happen."

Be careful what you wish for.

I'm ten years old and I'm not a ghost yet. My name is Isaac and I have a mother and a father and a big brother, Luke. I have a dog, too. His name is Jumper and he is my best friend. We go everywhere together. We swim in the river together; we chase chickens together.

"Make sure Jumper does not catch any chickens!" My mother always yelled this from the back porch.

"Why can't Jumper catch chickens?" I asked my father one evening, as we sat on the porch watching the stars.

"That's your mother's rule," he said.

"But *why*?"

"Because Jumper won't wait for the chickens to be cooked," he said. "He'll chew the chickens and choke on the bones and bloody feathers. Would you want to eat bloody feathers?"

"No," I said. "Good rule."

"Then make sure Jumper follows it."

"Hoke," I said, which means "okay" in Choctaw.

Jumper and I, we take long walks in the woods together, we tug weeds from the corn stalks together, and we spend the day and night together.

"No dogs in your bed!" This was another rule of my mother's, but Jumper was smart. He waited until my mother fell asleep, then he climbed under the covers with me. In the morning, when he heard my mother making noise in the kitchen, he jumped out of bed.

Maybe she knew Jumper broke the rule. Maybe she smiled and let him get away with it. She was a good mother and we had a happy life, mostly. I had too many chores and too little free time, but I knew if I could just wait till I grew up, I'd have all the free time I wanted.

Then came the day that changed everything. Without any warning, I saw the ghosts. I also saw things before they happened.

My father rose early that morning, long before sunrise. He left the house while it was still dark. He carried his shotgun and his bag of shotgun shells, so I knew he was going hunting.

I finished my chores and started tossing mudballs against the barn wall. Jumper barked and chased the mudballs, but only for a little while.

“I’m bored,” Jumper said. “Let’s chase chickens!”

We were on our way to the chicken pen when I saw my father coming home from the woods. He was carrying only his shell bag and his shotgun, so I knew something was wrong.

Usually he returned with a wild turkey or sometimes a deer. He never returned from a hunting trip with nothing. He walked through the back door and I followed him. He didn't say a word to me, just held up his hand to let me know I should stay outside.

I listened through the door.

"We must move," my father told my mother. "What do you mean 'we must move'?" my mother asked. "You better move! Go back to the woods and catch us something to eat!" She was laughing.

“No,” said my father, and he was not laughing. “There is Treaty Talk in town. We must move.”

I was only ten, but I knew what Treaty Talk meant. It meant the *Nahullos* wanted something. *Nahullos* were people that lived a few miles away. They were not Choctaws, like us. We were nice to them and they were nice to us. But Treaty Talk always meant something else, and that something else was never nice.

My father took my mother by the hand and she gave him a strange look. He led her to their room, closing the door behind them. I was afraid of Treaty Talk and I didn't want to listen, not anymore.

Maybe it will all go away, I thought. You never know when your life is about to change. Treaty Talk is why I became a ghost.